

Shore crabs

Although crabs are sea creatures adapted for living underwater, their tough waterproof shells and strong legs allow many of them to feed on the exposed shore at low tide. They have evolved modified gills that enable them to breathe air, giving them the opportunity to spend most of their lives on the open beach, up trees, and even far inland.

WOW!

Each female red land crab can lay 100,000 eggs, so between them the females release up to 1.5 trillion eggs into the ocean each year.



AQUALUNG

Crabs gather oxygen from the water using gills, like fish. But a crab's gills are inside a cavity that holds a supply of oxygenated water. As the oxygen in the supply is used up, more seeps into it from the air. This allows a common shore crab to live out of water for many hours, provided it keeps its gills moist.

◀ SHORE CRAB

This widespread crab feeds both in the water and on the shore, preying on mussels and other animals.

SCUTTling GHOSTS

Tropical ghost crabs are so well adapted to life on the open beach that they can drown if they stay underwater for too long. They live in burrows in the sand above the high tideline, emerging to search for edible scraps and animal prey. Their flip-up eyes have sharp vision and, at the slightest alarm, they scuttle sideways into their burrows at high speed. Many are also very well camouflaged, vanishing like ghosts when they stop moving.



LAND CRABS

Although shore crabs and ghost crabs are well equipped for living on beaches, they do not stray far from the sea. Other crabs have almost given up marine life, and are known as land crabs. They have gills, like all crabs, but their gill cavities are lined with blood vessels that extract oxygen directly from the air, just like our lungs. These crabs live and feed on land for most of the year, but they must return to water to lay their eggs.